Activity 4 — The Walk-In Interruption — Retail Service Counter, Bugis

Topic	4 — In-Person Customer Service
Mapping	LO1 · Handle in-person and at-your-desk requests using body language and acknowledgement.
Format	Role Play
Duration	15 minutes
Roles	Groups of 4. Role A = Service Officer, B = SIM customer, C = Ms Chen, D = observer/phone caller.

The Scenario

A telco retail store at Bugis Junction, Saturday 2pm. You are at the service counter finishing a SIM registration for a customer who is standing beside you waiting for the confirmation SMS. The store phone rings. At the same moment, Ms Chen walks up to your counter holding a phone with a cracked screen and says 'Excuse me, I just need a quick answer' — she has been in the store for 20 minutes looking for someone. Two more customers are visibly waiting behind her.

You cannot serve three people at once. Everything you do in the next 15 seconds is visible to all of them.

What You Will Produce

A demonstrated acknowledgement sequence handling three competing demands without losing any of them.

Materials: Observer checklist · Timer.

Discussion Questions

1. In the first 15 seconds, what do you do — and in what order? Be specific about words, eyes and hands.
2. Ms Chen says 'I just need a quick answer'. Is it ever actually quick? What is the risk of treating it as quick?
3. How do you acknowledge Ms Chen without abandoning the customer already at your counter?
4. The phone is ringing and no one else can take it. What do you do, and what does the customer in front of you see you do?

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5. What body language keeps all three parties feeling attended to while you can only serve one?

6. What is the 'park and return' method, and where exactly would you use it here?

Step-by-Step

1. Set up the physical space: a counter, A behind it, B standing at the counter, C approaching from the side, D at a distance with a phone.

2. Brief each role privately. C (Ms Chen) has already waited 20 minutes and believes her question is 30 seconds long. She is polite but firm.

3. Run ONLY the first 15 seconds. Freeze on the trainer's call. Observers describe exactly what A did with eyes, hands, torso and words — in that order.

4. Discuss the freeze-frame as a group for 2 minutes. Most first attempts either ignore Ms Chen entirely or abandon the SIM customer. Name which one happened.

5. Reset and run the full scenario for 6 minutes with the phone ringing at the 20-second mark.

6. A applies the sequence: acknowledge C within 3 seconds without leaving B; handle the phone with a callback offer; complete B's registration; note the park point; then turn fully to C.

7. When A turns to C, A must NOT ask her to repeat why she is there — A should open with 'you mentioned a cracked screen' to prove she was heard the first time.

8. Observer (D) scores the checklist and reports: acknowledgement time in seconds, whether any customer was made to repeat themselves, and whether A's torso ever fully turned away from the active customer.

9. Rotate roles so at least two learners play the Service Officer.

Debrief — What a Strong Answer Looks Like

- Order matters: eye contact + a raised hand + 'I'll be right with you, about two minutes' to Ms Chen takes 3 seconds and buys 2 minutes. Being SEEN precedes being served.
- 'Quick answer' is almost never quick — a cracked screen means warranty status, purchase date, insurance and a repair booking. Treating it as quick means starting something you cannot finish and now failing two customers.
- The customer in front of you keeps priority. State that openly to the room: it reassures the person you are serving AND tells the queue there is a fair rule.
- The phone: let it go to the queue or answer with 'may I take your number and call you back in five minutes?' Never leave a physical customer standing while you have a full phone conversation — the person present outranks the person calling.

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- Body language: keep your torso oriented to the counter customer, turn only your head to Ms Chen, and use an open palm rather than a pointed finger. Turning your whole body away is the abandonment signal.
- Park and return: note where you were in the SIM registration before you turn away, so you resume without asking the first customer to repeat anything. Making a customer re-explain is the failure this method exists to prevent.

Check Your Work

You acknowledged the walk-in within 5 seconds, no customer was asked to repeat themselves, and the observer confirms you never fully turned away from the customer you were actively serving.

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